Presentation about Sīmā – Part 2

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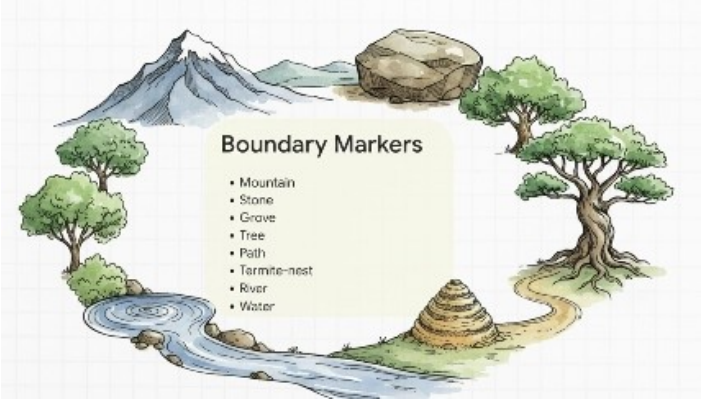
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Pointing out and binding

The earliest Vinaya procedure for establishing a *sīmā* was conceptually simple: monks *authorized* or *agreed upon* (*sammannati*) certain natural landmarks – a rock, a tree, a road – as the limits of their communal territory. The act was essentially one of collective recognition and consent, *pointing out (kitteti)* features that already existed in the landscape. Linear features such as rivers and roads were particularly useful in this early method precisely because they were unambiguous and easily recognizable: a river *is* a boundary in an intuitive, practical sense, and everyone could see it. The area of the early *sīmās* was typically very large, several kilometres across, and monks living there would regularly come together for the uposatha ceremony. They did not have access to a geographic map of the area on which ideal straight lines can be drawn. Instead, they would recognize the important landmarks of the area they lived in. For example, they could define their area by pointing out "from that hill over there, along the stream until it meets the road, then along the road until it reaches the pond, then up to a big rock on the edge of the forest, and along the forest back to the hill."



What the commentarial tradition did, particularly from the Samantapāsādikā onward, was to reframe this act through the metaphor of *binding (bandhati)*. Rather than monks simply agreeing that certain landmarks *are* the boundary, they now conceptually *connect* those markers to one another, as if drawing a line or pulling a rope from point to point in a clockwise circuit until the loop closes back on itself. This newer term emphasizes the ritual method of connecting boundary markers (*nimitta*) to delineate the territory. In the early Vinaya, a formally established territory is called *samāna-saṃvāsa sīmā* (territory of shared communion). Following the introduction of the root *bandh* in the commentaries, the term *baddha sīmā* (tied-off territory) became the standard designation.



The territory is now defined by the directional act of tying marker to marker. And this geometric logic imposed a new demand on linear features: a winding river or road as a whole could no longer serve as a marker, since a rope cannot be easily tied to it. A specific, singular point on that road or riverbank now had to be pinpointed, through which the imaginary connecting line would pass. The result of this process is a closed geometric figure with legal existence, the *baddha sīmā*, rather than a loose collection of agreed-upon landmarks. It has to follow the rules of valid polygon construction: each marker must be a genuinely distinct point on the perimeter, and the perimeter must fully enclose the territory without self-intersection.

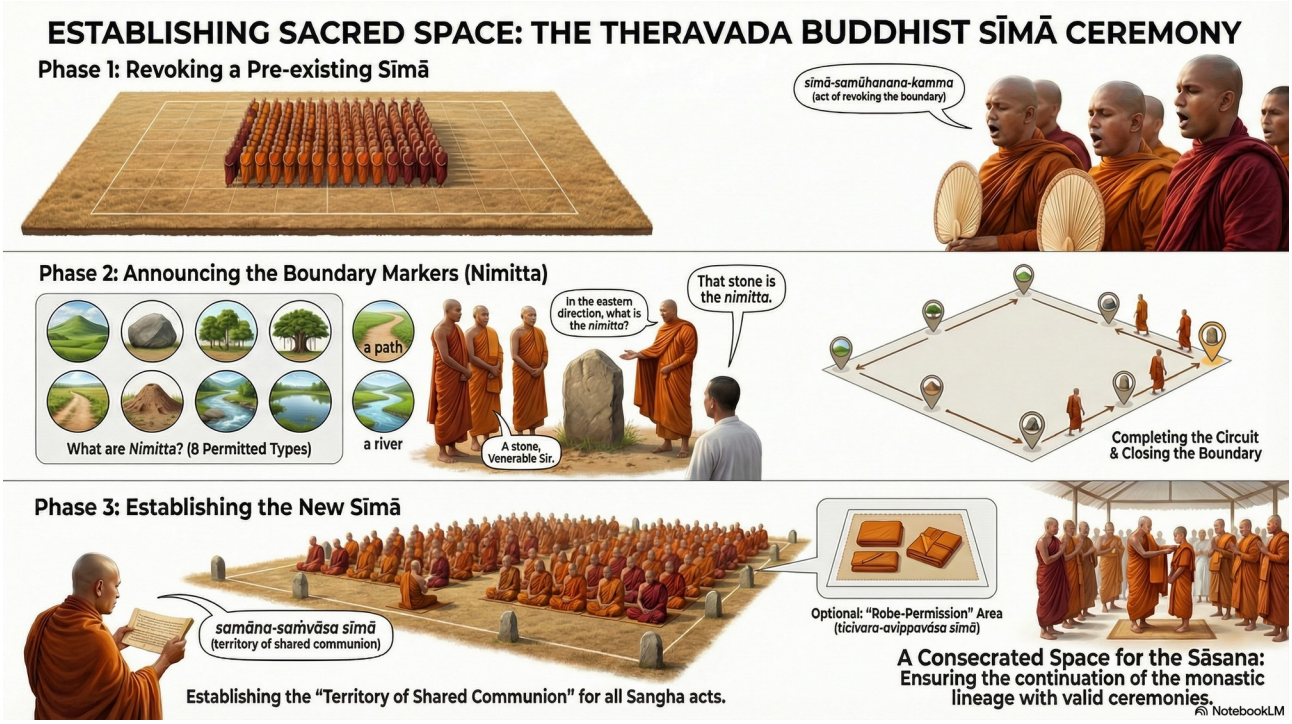
The eight directions

In the Vinaya Piṭaka, the eight cardinal and inter-cardinal directions are not mentioned as a requirement for establishing a *sīmā* boundary. Instead, the original canonical rules regarding boundary markers (*nimitta*) are far simpler, with the specific directional layout being a later commentarial development. The Mahāvagga simply states that these markers must be announced or pointed out (*kitteti*), but it does not describe the method for doing so, nor does it specify their number or placement:

> *Yāvatā samantā nimittā kittitā yadi saṅghassa pattakallaṁ saṅgho etehi nimittehi sīmaṃ sammanneyya samānasaṁvāsaṃ ekuposathaṃ.*
>
> If the Saṅgha is ready, then – as far as those markers that have been pointed out all around – it should authorize by those markers a territory of shared communion, of a single *uposatha*.

The practice of using eight markers specifically aligned with the eight cardinal and inter-cardinal directions originates in the later commentaries. The Samantapāsādikā (by Buddhaghosa, 5th century Sri Lanka) introduced the detailed ritual for "tying off" (*bandhati*) a territory. It describes a process where monks proceed clockwise from one marker to the next, eventually returning to the first marker to close the loop. It mentions the specific questions used to announce the eight directions (e.g., *Puratthimāya disāya kiṃ nimittaṃ* – "What is the marker in the eastern direction?"). Although it technically allows a *sīmā* to have anywhere from 3 to 100 markers, the rectangular shape became the standard.

The Vimativinodanī-ṭīkā originated in South India and was composed at the end of the 12th century. It was written by Coḷiya Kassapa, a South Indian monk. The subcommentary was written from the perspective of the South Indian (Coḷiya) monks during a period of significant interaction between South Indian and Sri Lankan monastic orders. The proximity allowed monks to observe deviating practices and differences in their Vinaya interpretation, which formed the basis for later legal disputes. As the third subcommentary on the Vinaya, it is noted for being highly innovative and more detailed than earlier works. It is the first Pāli text to describe certain new ritual techniques, such as the method for cancelling unknown *sīmā* territories. This method was unorthodox because older commentaries by Buddhaghosa considered it impossible to remove a *sīmā* whose exact location had been forgotten. Another innovation which it introduced was the replacement of the real name of *upasampadā* candidates with "Nāga" and that of the preceptor with "Tissa". Despite the dispute with the Sri Lankan tradition, the Vimativinodanī became highly influential across the Theravāda world and its new ritual forms are widely accepted as the standard until today.



What is a marker

The Vinayamukha composed by Vajirañāṇavarorasa has the following description:

> The marking of the *sīmā* with *nimitta* could be such as: in the east it extends from such-and-such a river to such-and-such a lagoon; in the south, from such-and-such a hill to such-and-such a range of rocks; in the west, to such-and-such a path; in the north, to the edge of such-and-such a grove.
>
> The use of these six kinds of *nimitta* suggests that in those days the areas of *sīmā* were large. *Sīmā* can be marked with these six objects as *nimitta*. Rocks, trees, ant-hills, ponds or wells, are also permanent things, but they are smaller than the six mentioned above. I understand that they are used as *nimitta* of *sīmā* located on mountains or in jungles which cannot be marked by groves or hills. Moreover, they are used in areas where larger objects are not available.
> …
> Paths. A footpath or a cart-track still in use can be used as a *nimitta*. A path of the length of two or three villages can be used. Paths which split from the main path and which join up again a short distance later and disused paths are prohibited from use.
> …
> Water means the still water in lagoons, marshes, ponds or wells. In the old commentary called the Andhaka-atthakathā it is prohibited to take the water in a deep well in which a pulley or something similar is used to draw out water as a *nimitta*. It is explained that in such wells the amount of water is very little and they can go dry. The *ācariya* who composed the Commentary on the Mahāvagga opposes that explanation as unsuitable, calling it only the author's own opinion. He himself explained still water as even that in a wallow dug by pigs in a children's playground, or even water which is brought by pot and poured into a pit which was dug that moment. If that water can remain until the end of the chanting of the *kammavācā*, however small an amount remains, this can be used. But in that place, he added, it is proper to construct a pile of rocks or a sand-hill or an earthen-hill, or a fixed rock, or a wooden pole as a marker. I am amazed that the *ācariya* who composed the Mahāvagga commentary dared to contradict a reasonable view so strongly and shamelessly, while (himself) comparing *vinaya-kamma* with playthings. He completely misunderstands the flavour (of the passage); it is quite disturbing.
>
> These objects are limited to being *nimitta* on one side only, and are prohibited from being used on another side. For example, the same path or the same river encircling the *sīmā* on many sides, if determined as *nimitta* on one side, is prohibited from being determined again on another side. However, they are used in marking a country's borders: after consideration, I can see no objection – these objects may be used either similarly or differently from the rest.

Prince Vajirañāṇavarorasa was exposed to English education and scientific approach as he was growing up in the palace of King Chulalongkorn (in the years 1872–1876). In his interpretations he often disagrees openly not only with the commentaries, but also with the Vibhaṅga itself, treating the base rules, the Vibhaṅga's case-law elaboration, and the later commentaries as separable layers to evaluate and sometimes reject individually. He displays independent analytical rationalism, having been trained in law and administration, and applying his own critical judgment to reconcile

or question the inherited tradition. King Chulalongkorn was an early patron and supporter of the Pali Text Society in England because he valued their work and general approach to publishing Pali texts. Chulalongkorn's circle of literate monks and princes was actively exchanging texts and manuscripts with Rhys Davids from the mid-1890s onward. During those years Vajirañāṇavarorasa was patriarch of the Dhammayuttika order, abbot of Wat Boworniwet, and was beginning the intellectual work that would become the Vinayamukha (written from 1913). It is very likely that he was influenced by the European historical-critical project of dating and stratifying the Pali texts according to their authenticity. Rhys Davids, as the secretary of the Royal Asiatic Society, wrote to Vajirañāṇavarorasa in 1898 to inform him that he has been

> "elected an Honorary Member of the Society in consideration of the distinguished services you have rendered to the attainment of the objects of the Society … and the distinguished merits of your Highness's work as a scholar and an editor of those ancient Pali texts, so important from the point of view of the Society."

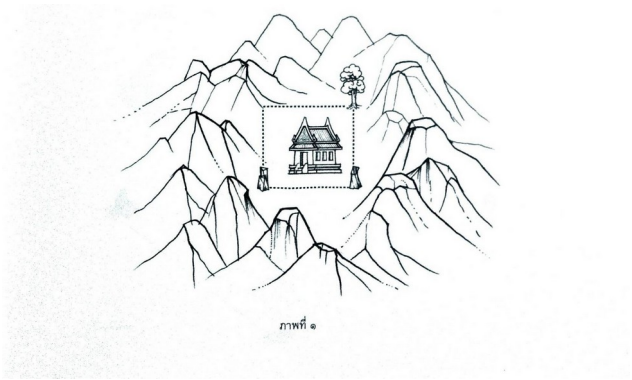
Here we can see that he questions the commentarial prohibition of using certain continuous landmarks like roads or rivers to mark the edge of the *sīmā*. There is no such stipulation in the original rule formulation in the Mahāvagga. Giving more weight to the older canonical text, he follows common sense and suggests that such continuous markers can be used differently from the more typical stone *nimitta*. This would of course challenge the standard shape of a perfect rectangle that has become the norm for *sīmā* since the time of the commentaries. In the early days the monks were more concerned with practical and easily discernible boundaries which used natural landmarks rather than idealized shapes.

The Samantapāsādikā commentary states:

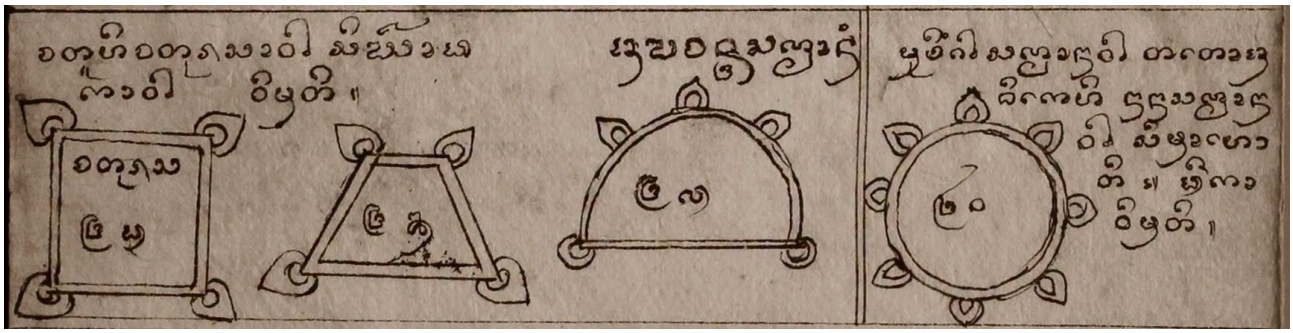
> *Tasmā pabbatanimittaṃ karontena pucchitabbaṃ "ekābaddho na ekābaddho"ti. Sace ekābaddho hoti, na kātabbo. Tañhi catūsu vā aṭṭhasu vā disāsu kittentenāpi ekameva nimittaṃ kittitaṃ hoti, tasmā yo evaṃ cakkasaṇṭhānena vihāraṃ parikkhipitvā ṭhito pabbato, taṃ ekadisāya kittetvā aññāsu disāsu … aññāni nimittāni kittetabbāni.*
>
> Therefore, when making a mountain-marker, one should ask: "Is it connected as one (*ekābaddho*) or not connected as one?" If it is connected as one, it should not be used. For even if one indicates it in four or eight directions, only one single marker has been indicated. Therefore, a mountain that stands encircling a monastery in the shape of a wheel – having indicated it in one direction, in the other directions ... other markers must be indicated.

In this context, *ekābaddho* means a mountain that is "connected as one" or "a single continuous mass," i.e., a mountain range or cliff that wraps around in multiple directions without clear separation. The commentary requires a valid *sīmā* to have distinct markers in all of its cardinal directions. If a mountain wraps all the way around (*cakkasaṇṭhānena*, "wheel-shaped", like a circular ridge), then naming it in multiple directions would still refer to the same geological feature. The commentary's solution is implicit in the passage: "other markers should be indicated" (*aññāni nimittāni kittetabbāni*), so they would need to use different kinds of markers at different points rather than relying on the encircling cliff alone.

There is actually a meditation monastery like that in Chiang Rai, completely surrounded by cliffs on all sides.



In some illustrated *sīmā* manuscripts from Thailand, however, other shapes are also described, such as a drum or a half-moon:



Luk nimit stones

> "Mention should also be made of the modern tradition of *luk nimit*, which is an integral part of the consecration ceremony today. *Luk nimit* are round stones, approximately 30 cm in diameter, buried in sets of nine, eight directly under *sema* and one in the centre of the *ubosot*. However, *luk nimit* have never been found in association with Dvaravati period *sema* from the Khorat Plateau. It seems clear therefore, that this tradition came in later, perhaps as early as the Sukhothai period."
>
> The Buddhist Boundary Markers of Northeast Thailand and Central Laos

The Vinayamukha author writes:

> The material to be used as *nimitta* must be prepared before. At present it is common to use stones because they are more convenient than other materials. The size, according to the Commentary, is rather small. I prefer stones of larger size, large enough so that they are

difficult to move. At present round stones are used placed in a pit and after the pit is filled in, a pillar or an arch-like structure is built over the *sīmā*-stone. Round stones roll about easily which I do not like, but they are frequently used. Placing them in pits is reasonable. If, after some time has gone by and that monastery is deserted, such *nimitta* may still remain in place, and indicate the extent of the old *sīmā* boundaries. *Nimitta* above ground can be too easily moved from the area, bur the original objective was for them to be visible objects like the city markers called ‘stone pillars’. Ancient monasteries in Kamphaeng Phet and Sukhothai cities used very large *sīmā*-markers fixed on the ground. I excavated at Wat Mahā Dhātu at Sukhothai, and found no *nimitta*-objects under the *sīmā*-markers. This means that they used the *sīmā*-marker itself as the *nimitta*. This agrees with the old tradition. According to the opinion of Somdet Phra Maha Samana Chao Krom Phraya Pavaresvariyālankarana, my preceptor, the *nimitta* stones should be set on the ground, not under the ground. They must be visible at the time of pointing them out. If trees were used as *nimitta*, they must be of the prescribed kind and big enough so that they cannot be moved to another place and planted there. If ponds or wells are to be used as *nimitta*, they should be those from which people normally draw water.

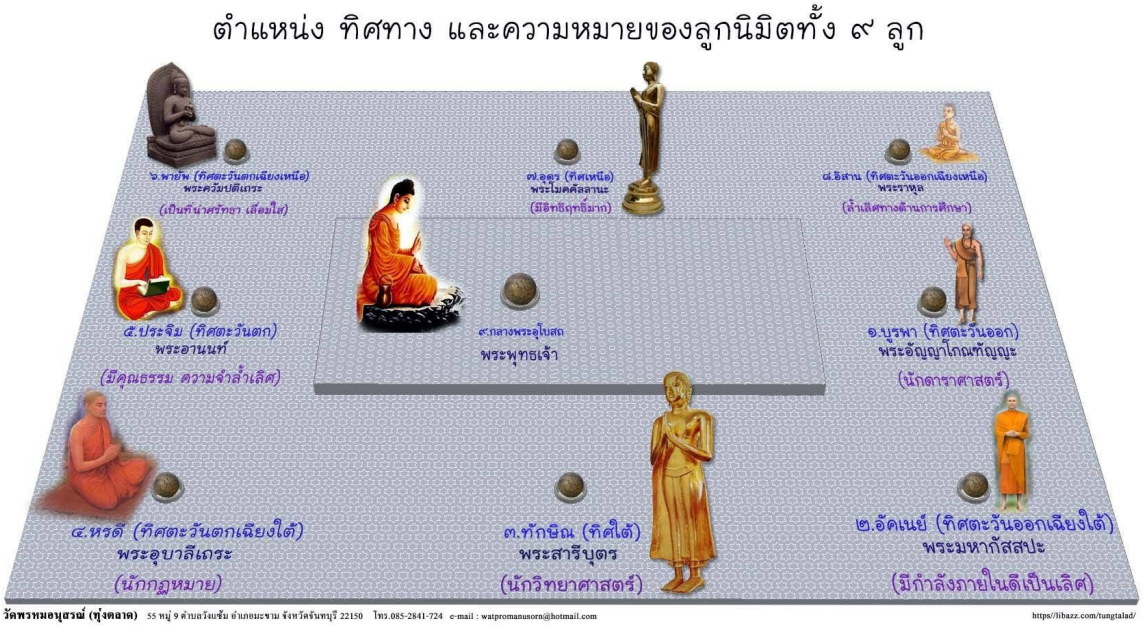


Following the Thai tradition, on an astrologically auspicious day, these *luk nimit* stones are lowered into the pits. The central, ninth stone is buried with the highest level of ceremony, often suspended by ropes and dropped into the central pit by cutting a ribbon with a ceremonial knife. This central stone, acting as a symbolic seed, is buried alongside precious woods, coins, jewelry, and written prayers to permanently seal the spiritual center of the temple. In Cambodia, this stone is specifically identified as the *indakhīla* (Indra’s stake), marking the “navel” of the consecrated area, which is something not found in Burmese and Sri Lankan traditions. The installation of the *sīmā* stones is a major religious occasion, traditionally led not by monks but by a lay ritual specialist known as *achar*. Shrines are erected to the directional deities at the eight compass positions around the vihāra, and the *achar* encircles them with a protective cotton thread before the pits are dug. Offerings such as shards of mirror, perfumed water, hair, nail clippings, musical instruments, or money are cast into the pit, and those present may cut a finger to let a few drops of blood fall in before the consecrated stone is lowered into place.

This ritual points to pre-existing animist beliefs that have been absorbed into the Buddhist ceremony. The ninth central stone appears sometime between the 13th and 15th centuries, when the Sukhothai kingdom was strongly influenced by the earlier Khmer empire from which it adopted many cultural aspects including Brahmanism. There is no archaeological record of this buried-stone tradition in the earlier Dvaravati period (6th - 11th century), where the above-ground stones themselves functioned as the actual *nimitta* markers. There are many esoteric elements and interpretations of Buddhist practices which were not present earlier in India or Sri Lanka, but were added in the Thai-Khmer cultural sphere. When Theravada Buddhism became Sukhothai's dominant public religion, Śaiva ritual and iconography survived underneath it, mainly through the institution of court Brahmanism and scattered Shiva shrines inherited from the Khmer period.

In Southeast Asian traditions (Thailand, Laos, Cambodia, Myanmar), the commentarial eight-directions model is always strictly followed. The central *luk nimit* stone represents the Buddha. Each direction is then ritually mapped to one of the first-generation disciples of the Buddha, creating a cosmic mandala that symbolically aligns the physical footprint of the temple with the primordial assembly of the early Buddhist community:

- East: Ven. Aññā Koṇḍañña
- South East: Ven. Mahā Kassapa
- South: Ven. Sāriputta
- South West: Ven. Upāli
- West: Ven. Ānanda
- North West: Ven. Gavampati
- North: Ven. Moggallāna
- North East: Ven. Rāhula





This eight-directions mandala appears to belong to a later ritual layer, the kind of cosmological protective symbolism (closer to a *maṇḍala* or *yantra* logic) that became prominent in Southeast Asian temple consecration practice, particularly in Thai, Lao, Khmer, and Burmese manuals (*tamrā*) used by ritual specialists when laying out temple grounds. The presiding monks will mentally invoke and chant blessings associated with these specific arahants at each corresponding compass point. This genre of practice – overlaying cosmological and astrological schemes onto architectural consecration – is generally associated with the medieval and early-modern period of Southeast Asian Buddhism. From the Ayutthaya period onward (14th - 18th century) indigenous ritual, Brahmanical, and cosmological elements were increasingly woven into monastic consecration practices alongside the canonical Vinaya framework.

Here is an example of a contemporary Thai instruction explaining the benefits of putting gold leaf on the *luk nimit* stones and dropping them into the pits surrounding the *ubosot*:

> Because in former times building an ordination hall was not an easy task and required a very long time, it is therefore believed that anyone who has the opportunity to make merit by burying a *luk nimit* stone will receive six kinds of blessings, namely:
>
> Freedom from illness and disease in every life, freedom from all misfortune.
> Never being born into a low family.
> If born as a human, one will be born as a great king or ruler.
> If born in the heavenly realm, one will be born as Sakka, king of the gods.
> One will be complete with wealth and possessions, with a radiant complexion.
> Lastly, one will have a long life.

It is also customary to place a notebook, a pencil, a needle, and thread into the pit where the *luk nimit* stone is buried, because it is believed this will grant a good memory, sharp wisdom like a needle, and continuous progress like the length of the thread.

In truth, burying the *luk nimit* stones to mark the boundary for Sangha ceremonies – or nowadays, to mark the boundary of the ordination hall – is a matter specifically for the monastic Sangha; laypeople or villagers have no part in it. However, since nowadays the ordination hall is not only a place where monks perform Sangha ceremonies, but also a religious site where Buddhists carry out other rituals as well, for anyone who wants to make merit to enhance their own good fortune, gilding and burying the *luk nimit* stone is another option for you. However, no matter what method we use to make merit, as long as we have a pure heart and true sincere intention, the resulting merit will certainly come to you.

I would like to recommend – for anyone who wants to sell land, buy land, sell a house, apartment, or ongoing project; anyone with a legal case involving land or a house, inheritance problems, property or house assets; anyone in real estate, construction engineering, architecture, interior design, or land/house brokerage; anyone with debt problems, mortgage or pawned land/houses, landlocked land, wanting to buy a house, refinancing, disputes with neighbours, family or sibling quarrels, a house at a fork in the road, at the start of a soi, with a house number containing 0-3-7-8-9, or a house where someone has died – please bring a copy of the relevant documents and place them at the principal *luk nimit* stone, in the “navel” at the center of the ordination hall, tucked into the bosom of the Earth Goddess (Phra Thorani), in order to receive the protective merit-power from the presiding Buddha image in the hall.

Of the nine *luk nimit* stones, one – considered the principal marker (นิมิตเอก) – is placed in the center of the ordination hall as an offering of worship to the Buddha. The remaining eight are arranged around the ordination hall in the various directions. These surrounding directions are called “the eight directions” and carry auspicious meaning, serving as symbols or representatives of the arahant disciples, as an act of worship toward the senior arahant disciples who guard the ordination hall or the Buddha’s consecrated monastic precinct (*buddhāvāsa*). They also serve as worship of the nine planetary deities, so as to generate merit and good fortune for oneself and one’s family.



Religious syncretism

> "Śaivism and Buddhism coexisted, competed, and creatively borrowed from one another—from royal courts and monastic institutions to artistic workshops and literary circles. Drawing on epigraphic, archaeological, art historical, and literary sources, the essays illuminate the fluid boundaries of the medieval religious landscape of South Asia. They trace the layered affiliations of kings and patrons, alongside the shared idioms that shaped poetry, iconography, ritual, and philosophy."
>
> Śaiva–Buddhist Encounters in Medieval India

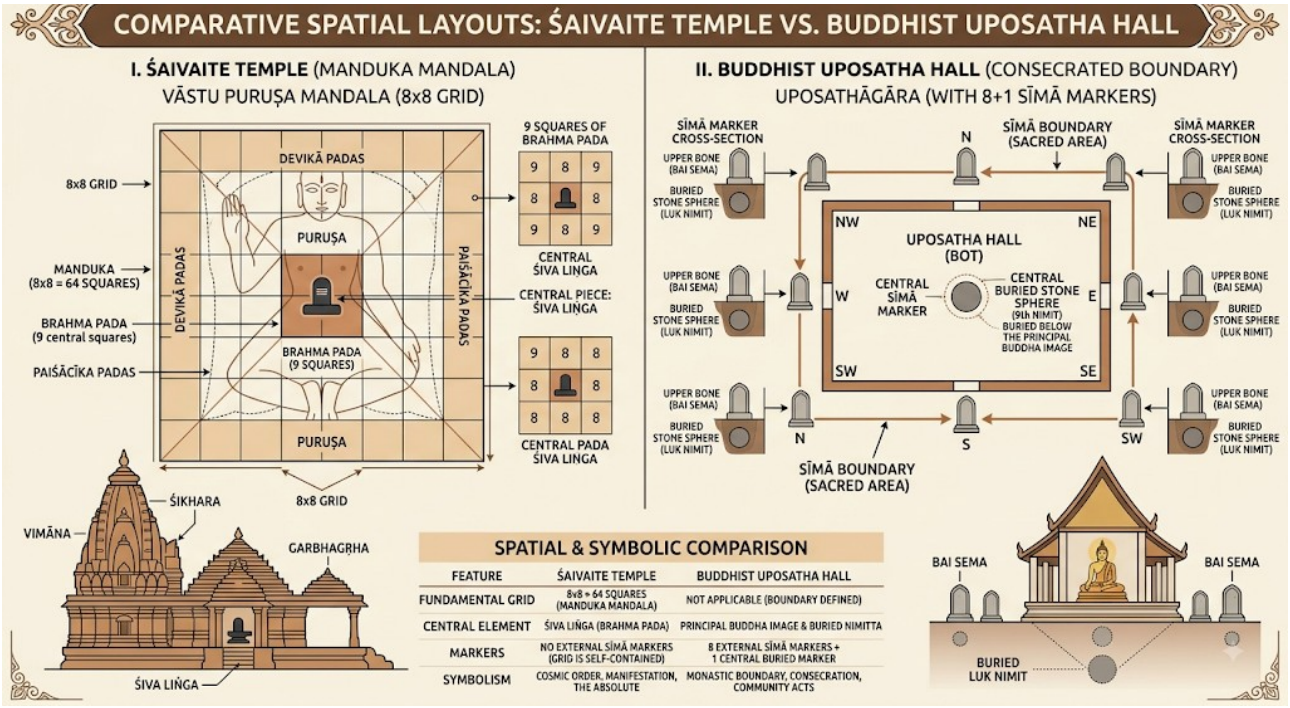
Medieval India, which usually means from the 6th century through the 13th century and overlaps closely with what the scholar Alexis Sanderson termed the "Śaiva Age", was an era when Tantric Śaivism became the dominant religious form of royal courts across the subcontinent. Tantric (Vajrayāna) Buddhism flourished in parallel, especially under dynasties like the Pālas of eastern India. Śaiva and Buddhist tantric systems developed side-by-side, borrowing ritual structures, mantras, and iconographic forms from each other. Similar process also happened in Jainism. This same period ultimately saw Buddhism's institutional decline in most of India by the 12th - 13th centuries, even as Śaivism continued to flourish.

In the Śaiva tradition of temple consecration (*pratiṣṭhā*), the central act is the installation of the *liṅga* over a pit at the heart of the *garbhagṛha*. Before the *liṅga* is set in place, the pit is filled with a *garbhanyāsa* ("womb deposit") consisting of gems, gold, seeds, and other substances, often arranged according to a *maṇḍala* scheme oriented to the cardinal directions, with rites invoking and propitiating local or earth deities so that the site is prepared to host the god. The *liṅga* is then lowered onto this deposit in a moment that is the ritual and symbolic climax of the whole consecration.

The Khmer *sīmā* ritual mirrors this template closely: directional altars at the eight compass points, offerings (mirror shards, hair, nail clippings, money, blood) cast into pits before the stones are lowered, and a central stone *(indakhīla)* buried beneath the main Buddha image as the climactic act, sometimes explicitly likened by scholars to the placement of a Shiva *liṅga* at a temple's centre. Both systems share the same underlying logic: a site must first be ritually pacified and "fed" through buried offerings to the earth or directional spirits before a sacred image or boundary can be fixed there, and in both cases a buried object at the centre functions as the anchor of the whole consecrated space.

Before any Śaiva temple is built, the site undergoes a preparatory rite of clearing and purification (*bhūparigraha*/*bhūśuddhi*), in which the architect-priest examines and ritually cleanses the ground, expelling or propitiating whatever spirits or impurities reside there. The site is then laid out as a square grid governed by Vedic conventions tracing back to the fire altar, with orientation along the cardinal directions extending the older Vedic ritual of the three fires. This grid, the *vastu-puruṣa-maṇḍala*, is most commonly an 8×8 (64-square) or 9×9 (81-square) arrangement, in which each sub-square (*pada*) is conceptually assigned to a deity, with the central squares reserved for Brahman. The ground plan functions as a symbolic, miniature representation of the cosmos, and the placement of each square corresponds to the rank of its presiding deity, with the most important squares at the centre marking the position of the temple deity itself. It is at this central point, the *brahmasthāna*, that the *garbhanyāsa* deposit and *liṅga* are eventually installed. See Hindu_temple_architecture.

Here are the two ground-plans side by side: a central axis point plus eight peripheral markers, laid over a square, purified plot.



Both traditions treat a building site as something that first has to be ritually “cleared” and then organized before anything sacred can be placed on it. Buddhist boundary-marking starts with revoking any old *sīmā* that might exist in that area, following the grid pattern in which a group of monks successively stands and chants until the entire plot has been covered.

Sīmā Removal Ceremony at Metta Forest Monastery, August 10, 2024
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=oqrp9SvT1kU

ขั้นตอนการสมมุติสีมา ตามพระวินัย
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dxL9nISYiw0

This way of clearing the area was not acceptable until the author of the Vimativinodanī subcommentary came up with it, in the 12th century in southern India. It is likely that he was inspired by the pattern of Śaiva temple purification and applied it to a Buddhist context, in order to solve the problem of revoking pre-existing *sīmā*. Buddhaghosa’s commentary is clear that a *sīmā* can only be revoked as a whole by the appropriate *saṅghakamma* if we know where the boundary markers are. To revoke little squares one by one somewhere inside it does not conform to the formal pattern of the rule. Alastair Gornall writes about the Pali literature that was composed in this era in Sri Lanka:

> “The ability of commentators to reshape doctrine has often been overlooked largely because the authors themselves were very conscious to present their work as a continuation or a recovery of tradition rather than something new. There is no doubt that commentators were generally conservative in that they respected tradition and were ever fearful of being viewed as schismatics. At the same time, if we move beyond their conservative rhetoric, we can

> begin to see these assertions for what they are: claims for authority that often mask the hidden politics and struggle over the development of doctrine."
>
> Rewriting Buddhism

The introduction of the central *luk nimit* stone in the Thai-Khmer cultural area is likely due to the fact that Brahmin priests who consecrated Śaiva temples also served Buddhist royal courts, adapting their methods of making land sacred to a Buddhist boundary-marking purpose. The small *sīmā* was always limited to eight stone markers surrounding the *uposatha* building with the ninth central stone placed in the middle. There are old inscriptions in Khmer characters which mention the presence of Brahmins at the *sīmā* ceremony, although the actual *saṅghakamma* must have been performed by monks alone. Brahmin rituals organize an entire temple as a cosmic layout centered on the deity, whereas Buddhist *sīmā* rituals establish the legal and sacred boundaries of a space for monastic ceremonies, using the central-and-eight-directions pattern.

Using the water-splashing sīmā

Udakukkhepa sīmā comes from *udaka* (water) and *ukkhepa* (throwing). It refers to a temporary boundary in a body of water, such as rivers, sea and natural lakes or ponds. It is a type of natural *abaddha sīmā* (not-tied-off territory) determined by splashing water all around. Monastic formal acts may be performed on boats, rafts, or fixed platforms, provided they are about "a splash's distance" from the shore, are not moving, and are not tied to the bank. In the case of a river or a canal, the water must flow continuously during the rainy season and be deep enough that a nun's lower robe would get wet when crossing it. The commentary says that if the stream meets this requirement during the rains, one can also use the dry riverbed in the same way during the hot season.



The Dhammayuttika Nikāya initially favoured the use of water-splashing boundaries (*udakukkhepa sīmā*) for ordinations. Later the practice gradually transitioned towards the use of permanent land boundaries (*baddha sīmā* or *visuṅgāma sīmā*) established strictly according to the Vinaya rules.

1. Origins and Initial Necessity (Reign of King Rama III)

When Vajirañāṇo Bhikkhu (Prince Mongkut, later King Rama IV) founded the Dhammayuttika order in 1833, he harboured serious doubts regarding the purity of the existing land boundaries (*visuṅgāma sīmā*) of that era, viewing them as potentially overlapping, invalid, or not fully aligned with the Vinaya rules. He chose to use "water *sīmā*" – floating rafts or boats anchored in the Chao Phraya river – for ordinations and the recitation of formal motions (*kammavācā*), as natural bodies of water are inherently pure and free from technical boundary disputes.

2. Establishment of Proper Land Boundaries (Reigns of Kings Rama IV–V)

As the Dhammayuttika order expanded and received royally granted land to construct official monasteries, conducting ceremonies on floating rafts or boats became impractical for larger monastic assemblies. Consequently, monasteries began consecrating tied-off land boundaries (*baddha sīmā*) on site, carefully demarcating *visuṅgāma* (separated from village) zones with utmost precision based on the Pali texts. During this era, both land boundaries (around *uposatha* halls) and water boundaries were used in parallel. For monks suited for key leadership roles or seeking ultimate certainty in their monastic status, it remained customary to undergo a re-ordination ceremony (*daḷhīkamma*) in a water boundary (such as Prince-Patriarch Vajirañāṇavarorasa in 1880).

3. Decline and Permanent Standardization (Late Reign of King Rama V)

The debate between "Water Monks" and "Land Monks" – which had caused factionalism among monks and lay devotees – led King Rama V to publicly declare support for the Land Monks to quell the dispute. Later, when the Prince-Patriarch Vajirañāṇavarorasa reformed the Sangha administration and standardized Vinaya procedures nationwide, he established firm protocols for boundary consecration and royal *visuṅgāma* land grants. As a result, all newly established Dhammayuttika monasteries were able to consecrate their own land boundaries around ordination halls beyond any doubt. The practice of *daḷhīkamma* and ordinations in water boundaries ceased to be a standard practice around the 1940s in Thailand. Today, every major Dhammayuttika monastery possesses an ordination hall with a consecrated land boundary (*baddha sīmā*). However, water boundaries remain a valid monastic boundary allowed by the Buddha which can still be utilized in some situations, such as overseas monasteries that have not yet constructed permanent ordination halls.



Land Monks vs. Water Monks

Autobiographical Narrative of His Royal Highness Prince Vajirañāṇavarorasa

Since the time King Rama IV Mongkut was ordained, the Dhammayuttika monks regarded water boundaries (*udaka sīmā*) as pure and beyond doubt. They distrusted the consecrated land boundaries (*visuṅgāma sīmā*), which do not appear in the Pali Canon but were merely recommended by the Commentators (Atthakathācariya) following inferences from the *sīmā* during times when monasteries did not yet exist as permanent standalone settlements. Thus, water *sīmā* were used for ordinations. Later, if any monk was slated to become a pillar of the Sāsana, senior monks would take him to undergo a re-ordination ceremony in a water *sīmā* – a practice called *daḷhīkamma* (strengthening ceremony).

At Wat Bovornives Vihara, this practice had lapsed for a long time; most senior elders there had not undergone *daḷhīkamma*. Somdet Phra Sangharāja (Pussadeva) had been ordained for over 20 Vassa before he finally underwent *daḷhīkamma*. This occurred when he was to recite the ordination motion (*kammavācā*) during the King's [Rama V] monkhood ordination. His Royal Preceptor stated that all the elders taking part in the royal ordination were those who had already performed *daḷhīkamma*, except for him alone – yet he was to play a vital role in that ceremony. Therefore, he had to undergo it. He likely did not think of Prince Phra Thammunhisthada, who was another monk who had not performed it either.

On the other hand, Wat Somanas Vihara continued the practice regularly – not strictly reserved for those destined to be key pillars of the Sāsana, ordinary newly ordained monks (*navaka*) underwent it as well. This eventually caused a split within the monastic community itself into “Water Monks” and “Land Monks”. Female lay devotees (*upāsikā*) of that monastery began fanning the flames, praising the Water Monks and looking down on the Land Monks, until a dispute broke out at one point. Before my own ordination, His Majesty stepped in to support the Land Monks. From then on, the talk of Water and Land Monks quieted down. Even if practised, it was done in private and not excessively as before.

When I was ordained, reverence for monks ordained in a water *sīmā* had not yet faded. Realizing that I was someone who would remain long-term in the Sāsana and would also have to serve as a pillar of the Sāsana, and seeing that monks within the same sect had differing practices depending on their monastery, I felt I ought to be someone who could harmonize with all sides. To achieve that, my foundational ordination must not be a source of reservation. Furthermore, as my original ordination took place sooner than usual, performing the *daḷhīkamma* re-ordination in a water *sīmā* would enable me to accomplish good work effectively.

I thus presented this intention to Venerable Chao Khun Ajahn, asking him to take charge of arranging it. He agreed, accepted the responsibility, and instructed me to go pay respects and invite the Royal Preceptor. The Royal Preceptor replied that attending in person might cause a stir; he instructed instead that his name be recited in comparison – acting as though there were no Preceptor, yet the ordination would still be valid.

However, Chao Khun Ajahn, Chao Khun Phrommuni, and I discussed the matter and agreed on a point in the *Kammākammavinicchaya* (Judgments on Formal Acts vs. Non-Acts): “A formal act that must be performed face-to-face, if done behind someone's back, suffers from an invalidity of object (*vatthu-vipatti*) and is not a deed properly performed according to the Dhamma.”

If the *upasampadā* (ordination) procedure must be conducted face-to-face before the Preceptor, then if the Preceptor is absent from the monastic assembly and his name is merely

recited, the ceremony would suffer from a procedural invalidity (*kamma-vipatti*). The notion that an ordination remains valid without a Preceptor present was on precarious ground and could not be taken as reliable standard.

We therefore agreed that I would take Chao Khun Ajahn as my new Preceptor during the *daḷhīkamma*. Because Chao Khun Phrommuni had broken teeth – which could cause misgivings during recitation – Chao Khun Ajahn selected Chao Khun Dhammatrailok (Thānacāra) of Wat Debsirindravas (who was then a Pali scholar at Wat Somanas Vihara) to be the *kammavācācariya* (motion reciter). He accepted and made all the arrangements, taking me to perform the *daḷhīkamma* on a floating raft anchored in the river directly off the bank of Wat Rajadhivas.

It took place on Saturday, the 7th waning moon of the 2nd lunar month, Year of the Rabbit, 1241 C.S. (January 3, 1880 C.E.). First, I requested dependence (*nissaya*) upon the new Preceptor, then performed every step of the ordination procedure, reciting both Magadha (Pali) and Rāman (Mon) *kammavācā*. The first chant concluded at 11:00 pm. Once the *daḷhīkamma* was completed, Venerable Chao Khun instructed me to return to taking dependence (*nissaya*) under my original Teacher as before. Thus, I have called him "Chao Khun Ajahn" ever since.

https://www.silpa-mag.com/history/article_6824

Daḷhīkamma: The act of making something firm or strong; a re-performance intended to ensure validity in cases where the initial act might be incomplete. For instance, a monk ordained in the Mahānikāya sect who moves to reside at certain Dhammayuttika monasteries may be required to undergo *daḷhīkamma*.



Udakukkhepa Sīmā of Khlong Nong Bua

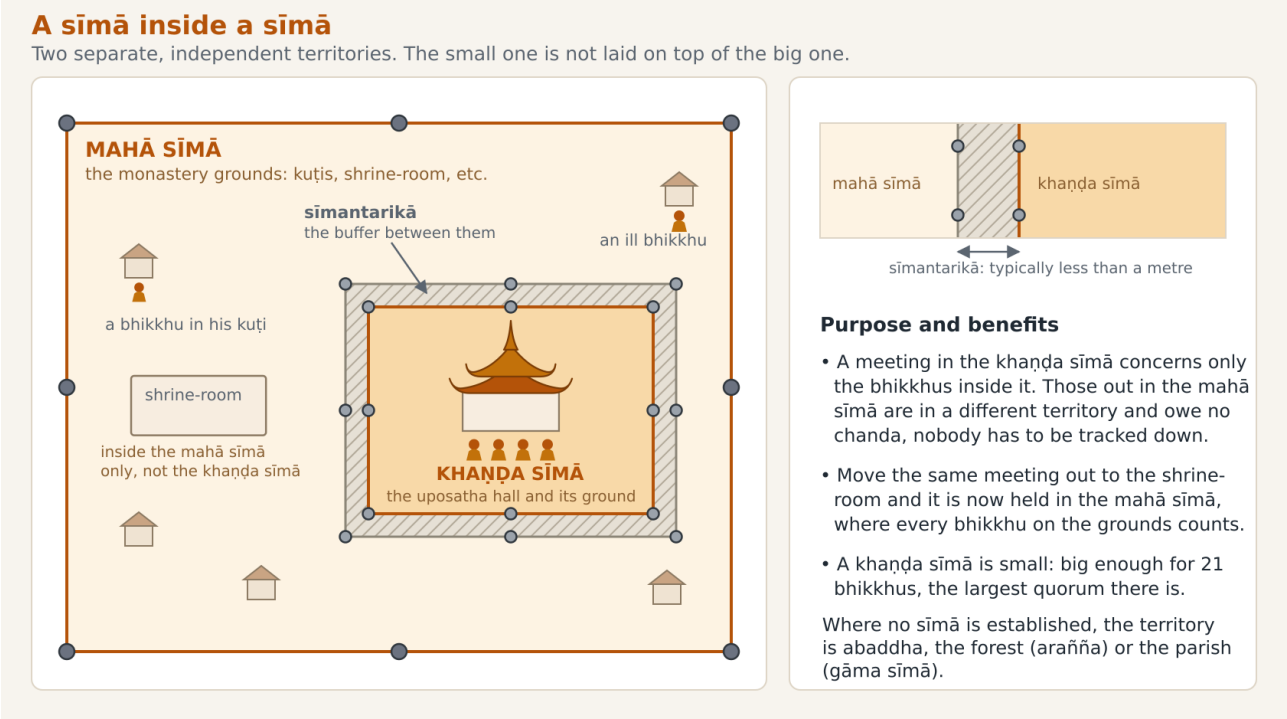
Somdet Phra Ñāṇavajiradom (Luang Por Viriyang Sirindharo) was ordained on 20th May 1941 at Wat Sai Ngam, Nong Bua Subdistrict, Mueang District, Chanthaburi Province. At that time, Wat Sai Ngam did not yet have an ordination hall, so Khlong Nong Bua was used as an *udakukkhepa sīmā* (water-splashing boundary). The canal is about 2 kilometers from the temple. Three boats were joined together side by side, with planks laid across them to form a flat platform. Khlong Nong Bua, though just an ordinary canal, served as the legally valid *sīmā* boundary for the ordination of Luang Por Viriyang Sirindharo, demonstrating the complete legitimacy of his *upasampadā* in strict accordance with the Vinaya. Today, his disciples have jointly erected a sign to mark and confirm the historical location of this *udakukkhepa sīmā*, so that devotees may continue to remember and honour it.

"อุทกุกเขปสีมาคลองหนองบัว" สถานที่หลวงพ่อวิริยังค์ สิรินฺธโร อุปสมบท เมื่อปี พ.ศ. ๒๔๘๔
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=M9RnvMk2Zlc



There is also a Dhammayut monastery in Chonburi province which is called Wat Udakakhepasīmārām (วัดอุทกเขปสีมาราม). It was established during the reign of King Rama V next to a canal. Although they might have historically used the canal as their water-splashing boundary for ordinations, the name of the monastery just preserves the memory of the past and now there is a standard *uposatha* hall.

วัดอุทกเขปสีมาราม (วัดน้ำ) ต.วัดโบสถ์ อ.พนัสนิคม จ.ชลบุรี
https://youtu.be/ZTI9SgrVPgk



Mahā sīmā and khaṇḍa sīmā

As part of the reforms initiated by King Mongkut in the mid-19th century Siam, there was an attempt to return to the early Buddhist use of large *sīmā* territories. For many centuries, only small-sized *sīmā* boundaries have been traditionally established in Theravada countries. They covered the area of the *uposatha* hall and its immeditate surroundings, not the entire monastery. No monks actually lived in this zone which was reserved just for ceremonial occasions. King Mongkut corresponded with learned Sri Lankan monks about this subject and also studied the Mon traditions. He wrote the Sīmāvicāraṇa in which he tries to clarify doubtful points. He also supervised the establishing of *mahā sīmā* territories which covered the complete grounds of some royally sponsored Dhammayuttika monasteries in Bangkok.

> The Thai narrative on Somdet Phra Vannarat Daeng insists that Daeng studied the rules for determining a large *sīmā* (*mahāsīmā*), a small *sīmā* (*khaṇḍasīmā*) and an interval between the two (*sīmantarikā*) from King Mongkut (1804–68; rg. 1851–68), particularly during the consecration of the *sīmā* at Wat Pathum Wanaram in Bangkok (begun in 1857, finished in 1861, and officially opened in 1867). But it also states that Daeng studied the methods for establishing a *baddhasīmā* directly from the manual of King Mongkut. It is well known that King Mongkut wrote a treatise on *sīmā* in 1844 while he was still a monk.
>
> In it he also discusses *mahāsīmā*, *khaṇḍasīmā* and *sīmantarikā*, but these *sīmā* forms do not stand in the focus of this treatise. A passage from the Thai narrative in the Sīmākathā makes it probable that he also wrote at least one manual containing diagrams. With regard to the establishment of the *mahāsīmā* at Wat Pathum Wanaram at that time, King Mongkut shared his concerns with Krommameun Udomaratanarasi, a half-brother of King Mongkut, that in the future, in terms of this particular ritual for establishing a *mahāsīmā*, including the

khaṇḍasīmā and the *sīmantarikā*, there will be no one who will know how to do it or who would have seen it done, and if so it will surely decay and disappear, especially among the monks of the Mahānikāya.

And so the king commanded Krommameun Udomaratanarasi to have Somdet Phra Vannarat Daeng, who at that time was a member of the Mahānikāya council, to come study the establishment of the *sīmā* in accordance with the plan for Wat Pathum Wanaram, with the king himself furnishing hand-written diagrams.

Sīmā treatises with a focus on illustrated manuscripts

King Rama IV used the concept of a *mahā-sīmā* (great *sīmā*) and built it into many temples he erected, especially Wat Rajapradit Sathit Mahasimaram, where he specifically dedicated it to the monks from Dhammayuttika-nikāya. Unlike other temples built by King Rama IV, however, the *mahā-sīmā* stones at Wat Rajapradit are unique as they were inscribed and put right in the wall of the temple without the demarcation of a *khaṇḍa-sīmā* (inner *sīmā*) inside. The *mahā-sīmā* therefore marks the boundary of the temple as well as the boundary where the monks can perform the *saṅghakamma*s (legal or ecclesiastical acts of a community) according to the Vinaya. …

That eight *mahā-sīmā* stone pillars, called *nimitta mahābaddha-sīmā* (great bounded *sīmā* markers) by the king, surround the whole temple indicates that the compound was demarcated as both ordination and congregational space. It has only a small *vihāra* called phra wihan luang, which serves as the main chapel, and a *cetiya* right behind it. This is untraditional since Thai temples commonly have both an *uposatha* hall and *vihāra*. While an *uposatha* hall is marked by *khaṇḍa-sīmā* markers and serves as the space for *saṅghakamma*s, a *vihāra* is not marked as a *khaṇḍa-sīmā* and generally serves as congregational space and not as a space for *saṅghakamma*s.

In the case of Wat Rajapradit, King Rama IV was concerned that the Dhammayuttikā Order may not be supported by successive reigns, so the area of the temple is small so it could support itself without royal patronage. Therefore, it was more practical to demarcate the whole temple as a *mahā-sīmā* so that it could serve as the place for the *uposatha* itself. This allowed all *saṅghakamma*s to be performed anywhere in the temple. ...

Interestingly, the concept of the *mahā-sīmā*, which had become a common practice in many royal Dhammayuttikā temples, was later extended to Mahā-nikāya temples, namely Wat Phothinimit Sathit Mahasimaram in Thonburi, founded by the Venerable Somdet Phra Wannarat (Daeng Sīlavaḍḍhano, 1822–1901) in the 1870s and Wat Benchamabophit Dusitwanaram founded by King Rama V in 1899. The demarcation of the *mahā-sīmā* in these two temples highlights the point that Venerable Somdet Phra Wannarat's knowledge and expertise on *sīmā* drew directly from King Rama IV when the king built Wat Pathum Wanaram and invited Somdet Phra Wannarat to observe the demarcation. …

In addition, when he built Wat Phothinimit on property he inherited from his parents, after the *khaṇḍa-sīmā* was demarcated as commonly practiced, he also demarcated the *mahā-sīmā* with the approval of King Rama V and the Supreme Patriarch Sa Pussadeva, one of the great

Dhammayuttikā masters. This seems to be the first significant case in which a Mahānikāya temple adopted the concept of *mahā-sīmā* originally initiated and practiced in the Dhammayuttikā Order.

Like Wat Phothinimit, the temple has both *khaṇḍa-sīmā* and *mahā-sīmā*. According to the documents, the *khaṇḍa-sīmā*s of Wat Benchamabophit were first demarcated in March 1899. Two months later, King Rama V dedicated more land around the *khaṇḍa-sīmā*s intending to demarcate the *mahā-sīmā* as suggested to him by Somdet Phra Wannarat.

The style of *sīmā* markers at Wat Benchamabophit is also unique. The *nimitta*s that surround the *uposatha* of Wat Benchamabophit are buried underneath with only small signs and pillars on the surface; no *sīmā* tablets or stones were erected as commonly practiced. Each of the nimitas has an inscription stating King Rama V's dedication of the land and merit. The markers of the *mahā-sīmā* were incorporated into the outer fence of the temple, but instead of stone they were made of cement pillars decorated with lotus-like tops.

The cases of Wat Phothinimit and Wat Benchamabophit clearly demonstrate that the concept of *mahā-sīmā*, as put into practice by King Rama IV, was accepted by his successor King Rama V and Somdet Phra Wannarat, the great master of the Mahānikāya Order. The concept influenced the demarcation of *sīmā* in at least two Mahānikāya temples during the period when the royal court pursued strict orthodoxy in Buddhist teaching and practice, even in the Mahānikāya temple.

Sīmās: Foundations of Buddhist Religion



Pattaratorn Chirapravati on Boundary Markers (Sima) & the New Buddhist Lineage of King Rama IV
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mq_HOXpN1q8

Wat Boworniwet Vihara was an existing temple prior to Vajirañāṇo Bhikkhu's accession to the throne. … In this endeavor, Vajirañāṇo Bhikkhu expanded the Sīmā boundary of Wat Boworniwet Vihara from its former position attached directly to the chapel walls to cover a wider surrounding area, using trees and stone pillars as Nimitta. By taking a tree as a *nimitta*, Vajirañāṇo Bhikkhu reverted to adopting one of the eight ancient boundary markers from the Buddha's era. … Starting at Wat Rajadhiwas (Wat Samorai), Vajirañāṇo Bhikkhu began by reconsecrating a new *khaṇḍasīmā* based on the principle of Sīmā boundary purity, adhering to the Mon monastic traditions inherited according to the Kalyānī Sīmā Inscription. The next temple, Wat Boworniwet Vihara, saw Vajirañāṇo Bhikkhu returning to prioritize details in the Tipiṭaka by using trees and stone pillars as *nimitta* to expand the Sīmā boundary beyond conventional Bai Sema. Later, he added a *mahāsīmā* boundary area along the walls of Wat Borommaniwas to separate it from the *gāmasīmā* (community boundary). Evidence shows that the Sīmā consecrations at both Wat Boworniwet Vihara and Wat Borommaniwas incorporated the step of requesting *chanda* (consent) into the consecration ceremony.

The Making of the Sīmā Boundary Markers of Wat Rajapradit Sathit Mahā Sīmārām



The natural uposatha hall at Suan Mokkh

Buddhadāsa Bhikkhu was another reform-minded Thai monk who was influenced by the writings of Vajirañāṇavarorasa and his translations of the original Pali texts. At Suan Mokkhabalarama monastery, Buddhadāsa rejected building a roofed ordination hall (*uposatha*), choosing instead a natural hilltop as an open-air *uposatha*, marked only by a line of stones laid out as the boundary, with trees as walls and the sky as roof. He explained his reasoning:

> "To keep it simple and economical, as close as possible to the Buddha's time. In the Buddha's day there were no ordination hall buildings like today. The Buddha specified using bare ground, or a residential hall – as long as it was within the *visuṅgāma sīmā*, it could be used."

Before being officially granted the status of a *visuṅgāma sīmā* by the authorities, Buddhadasa used this hilltop area as an *araññа sīmā* or forest boundary a few times, as it was far from any village. After the authorities approved the consecration ceremony, boundary markers were placed to encompass the entire area, making this place a legitimate temple for performing monastic rituals.

What clearly reflects the stance of Buddhadāsa Bhikkhu is his rejection of the "burying the stone markers (*fang luk nimit*)" ceremony, because he believed that it often became a money-making tool for temples rather than being of significant importance according to monastic rules. The stone markers at Suan Mokkh were left as plain, unworked natural stones laid on the ground rather than the polished, gilded *luk nimit* balls typical of modern Thai temples.

โบสถ์สวนโมกข์ หรือ "โบสถ์เขาพุทธทอง" อุโบสถกลางธรรมชาติที่สะท้อนอุดมคติของท่านพุทธทาส
https://main.bia.or.th/244120/

Conclusion

We can see that it is not easy to go against long-established tradition in Buddhist countries. Even for a king introducing reforms, they might not always take hold and be widely adopted. Thus, the *mahā sīmā* boundaries were only limited to a few royal temples in Bangkok. It would require a shift in the way of thinking and using *sīmā* boundaries on a larger scale for them to become widespread. In the West, however, we can choose how we wish to approach this: Some monasteries will follow the traditional Thai way of burying stone balls with elaborate ceremony, others might decide to go back to the original principles of designating large *sīmā* boundaries. Often this might depend on the status of a particular monastery and whether there are expectations to conform to official Thai customs. Smaller monasteries should have more freedom in this respect and use natural landmarks as *sīmā* markers.

Chithurst khandasīmā and boundary stones

